again – adding, modestly and pragmatically, ‘If the tale be true’[33] – did he wonder why he worried about clerics and mansabdars grumbling and gossiping in the bazaars of Fatehpur when the faith of his people grew stronger by the day? It was on this trip to Ajmer, at any rate, that he ordered Abdun Nabi and Makhdum-ul-Mulk into exile.

The two men must have seen it coming. Two years earlier, in December 1577, Akbar had dissolved the powers of his sadr, Abdun Nabi, and distributed his judicial duties across multiple offices in the various provinces of Hindustan. The emperor was tactful about it, explaining that the job was ‘larger than one person can control’,[34] but tactically, Akbar had done to Abdun Nabi and his ulema what he did to his warlords: curtailed their independence and made what power he left them dependent on his own.

Unlike the warlords, moreover, neither Abdun Nabi nor Makhdum-ul-Mulk seems to have been able to gather support to fight Akbar. Abdun Nabi’s arrogant disbursal of grants, spraying used water on his petitioners’ faces, could not have endeared him to them. Of Makhdum-ul-Mulk, Badauni writes that his greed was such that he would transfer his property to his wife at the end of every year, to avoid paying the compulsory Islamic tax, zakat, and ‘practised some other tricks of which even the Israelites would have been ashamed’. As for his piety, Badauni tells of a convoluted argument that Makhdum-ul-Mulk had come up with to avoid the Haj. To go to Mecca, he said, would mean traversing Shia Iran or suffering the heresy of a Portuguese passport stamped with ‘pictures of Mary and Jesus (peace be upon Him!)’. Therefore, the Haj became sinful, and its avoidance a virtue.

One can imagine Badauni and others chortling at the fate that banished the two old men on this very pilgrimage, but it is hard not to feel a little pity for them – once so powerful that people trembled at their names, now scrabbling for relevance. Ever since they felt the emperor’s favour turn cold, the jurists had been struggling to please him. Makhdum-ul-Mulk, who would have had Shaikh Mubarak executed for blasphemy; Abdun Nabi, who once scolded the emperor for using saffron during a birthday ceremony – throwing his stick at Akbar in anger![35] – were now willing to say anything to gratify the emperor’s irreverent spirit. They would even, writes Badauni,